ideas borrowed from other traditions and thought systems, and these have led to behaviour patterns arising out of the deep transformations within China itself, as well as in Asia and the world. The ideas of Mackinder [1] and Mahan [2] are as much discernible in Chinese strategic thinking today as are the concepts derived from the writings of the ancient Chinese strategist Sun Zi. The One Belt One Road project, now known as the BRI, is Mackinder and Mahan in equal measure; the Belt is designed to secure the vast land mass of Eurasia, which Mackinder called the World Island, dominance over which would grant global hegemony. The Road, which straddles the oceans and which would enable maritime ascendancy, is the indispensable element in pursuing hegemony, according to Mahan.

There is an unmistakable American flavour in China seeking singular predominance at the top of a regional and global order, where the hierarchical principle is the guarantee of order. But it also echoes the Chinese sage Confucius, who argued that harmony and hierarchy were intertwined. As long as each person knew his place in the pecking order and practised conduct appropriate to it, peace and order would prevail. When extended to China's relations with the outside world, there is a similar application of the hierarchy principle. When Xi Jinping talks about the 'rejuvenation' of China, he envisages an Asian order which is headed by China, with other countries ranged in subordinate positions.

China uses templates of the past to construct a modern narrative of power. It claims that through most of recorded history China was the dominant power in Asia, to which countries on its periphery rendered deference. The 150 years stretching from the Opium Wars in the middle of the nineteenth century to the establishment of the PRC in 1949 – a period when China was reduced to a semi-colonial status and subjected to invasions by imperialist powers and Japan – is characterized as an aberration.

It is true that there were periods in Chinese history when its periphery was occupied by relatively weaker states. But, as this book makes clear, China was itself occupied and ruled by non-Han invaders, including the Mongols from the twelfth to the fifteenth centuries and the Manchus from the fifteenth to the twentieth centuries. Far from considering these alien